great affability with his people. ‘It is hard to exaggerate how accessible he makes himself to all who wish audience of him,’ he writes. Public audiences were a daily affair, and Akbar would be ‘pleasant-spoken . . . rather than severe toward all who come to speak with him’, adopting a manner that had a ‘remarkable’ effect, in Monserrate’s opinion, ‘in attaching to him the minds of his subjects’.

A little over a decade later, Father Xavier led the third and last Jesuit mission to Akbar’s court and observed two equally telling scenes. In one, a vassal king came to Akbar to pay tribute, performing every manner of obeisance, bowing to the ground, touching the emperor’s feet, and offering grand presents, from jewelled daggers and goblets to horses and camels dressed ‘in green and crimson velvet’. All of this Akbar acknowledged with no more than placing ‘his hand on his vassal’s neck’.[14] The emperor was far more animated, by contrast, when some young women arrived at his court, having prayed in his name for children, or for a child’s health, and now, their wishes fulfilled, bringing Akbar ‘offerings, as to a saint, which, though they may be of little worth, are willingly received and highly valued by him’.[15]

It was clear to the Fathers, by this time, that Akbar wasn’t interested in converting to Christianity so much as he wanted to be ‘esteemed as a God, or some great Prophet’; and the priests could do as little about it as Badauni. For a great number of his subjects, Akbar was clearly a saint-king, performing miracles and ‘healing the sick with the water with which he washes his feet’.[16]

It wasn’t the case, however, as both the Fathers and Badauni suggest, that Akbar was mesmerizing the credulous masses with miracles. Sometime in 1580, when the Bengal rebellion was raging and two years after the emperor had gone into a trance before a qamargah hunt, Akbar had another of his epiphanies. It happened as he was eating.

~

Akbar’s ‘lofty’ mind and disposition was such, of course, that Abul Fazl would like us to know that ‘the question “What dinner has been prepared today?” never passes over his tongue’.[17] From the historian’s own detailed, sometimes mouth-watering, account of the imperial kitchen and its recipes,